

Testing the return migration element of the ‘escalator region’ model: an analysis of migration into and out of south-east England, 1966–2001

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According to the three-stage ‘escalator region’ hypothesis, the final ‘stepping-off’ stage involves people leaving the region towards the end of their working lives, limiting the economic benefits for the regions to which they move. Drawing on data on migration between the south-east and the rest of England and Wales, however, this paper reveals a more positive picture for these other regions. One in three of the younger people who moved to the south-east between 1966 and 1971 had left it again by 1981, and most of the working-age people leaving the south-east were aged under 30 years.

Keywords: escalator region, return migration, ONS Longitudinal Study, England and Wales, career progression, life-course perspective

JEL Classifications: J24, J61, J62

Introduction

The rise of the knowledge economy within the context of continuing globalization and increasing competitiveness has led to heightened awareness of the fact that the economic growth of regions and cities is closely tied to the quality of human capital available to them in the form of talented and aspiring workers (Dunning, 2000; Edmonds, 2003; Florida, 2000; Glaeser and Saiz, 2003; Malecki, 2007). Well-endowed places are characterized by higher rates of productivity and, through their greater ability to innovate and adapt, tend to be more resilient through economic downturns and be better placed to meet the challenges of industrial restructuring (Berry and Glaeser, 2005; Christopherson et al., 2010; Martin, 2012; Montgomery, 2006). In a process of path dependency (Boschma, 2004; Martin and Sunley,

2006), the possession of superior human capital resources leads to the accumulation of further advantage through a better developed capacity to reproduce occupational skills and business acumen in these ‘learning regions’ (Florida, 1995; MacKinnon et al., 2002). This tendency towards uneven regional development can be reinforced by the migration of people who want to ‘get on’ in life and reckon this ambition to be most readily achievable by relocating to where the promotion prospects seem brightest, especially where these people comprise university graduates and other talented people (Champion et al., 2007; Faggian and McCann, 2009; Florida, 2008; OECD, 1996). It is this latter line of reasoning that drives the escalator region model as originally set out by Fielding (1992).

In its full elaboration, Fielding’s model comprises three elements. The first two operationalize

the process just described, with people moving to the region early in their careers and then taking advantage of the greater upward social mobility there compared with where they were living previously. The final element involves people ‘stepping off the escalator’ by leaving the region when they have little more to gain from remaining there and indeed can benefit from moving to a region with lower living costs and a higher quality of life. The original tests of this model, as presented by Fielding (1992) on migration into and out of south-east England 1971–1981, proved positive, while subsequent analyses for 1981–1991 (see below) revealed the durability of this phenomenon. However, while these studies used the linked census records of the Office for National Statistics Longitudinal Study of England and Wales (LS), they all focused on single inter-censal decades and so could not examine the life-course nature of the spatial aspects of the escalator process. In particular, they left unresolved the question of the extent to which those moving to the region subsequently moved out of it and were therefore not able to tell whether those individuals who did complete the circuit of stepping on and off the escalator made the latter move near the end of their working lives or earlier than this.

Some more recent studies (see below) have suggested that a significant proportion of migrants to the escalator region stayed only a relatively short time rather than for the majority of their working lives, but these have been based on special-purpose surveys with much smaller sample sizes than are available for LS-derived analyses. The research on which the present paper is based takes advantage of the full longitudinal span available from the LS, which now contains information on the whereabouts of (surviving) individuals at the four census dates from 1971 to 2001 and also in 1966, thanks to the 1971 census question on address 5 years ago. This approach allows the examination of a substantial period of career development for those who moved to south-east England between 1966 and 1971, for whom the LS can show whether or not they were still living in this region up to three decades later and also give their work situation and

social status both shortly after their move and at the three subsequent time points.

The rest of the paper begins with a review of the literature on the escalator region and the various tests that have been carried out on it thus far, giving particular attention to results relating to the final ‘stepping-off’ element and providing a more detailed justification for the present study. Then details are given of the data and approach, stressing the value of tracing people’s spatial and social mobility through four census points. The section on findings tackles three related questions: how common it is that people stepping onto the regional escalator step off it again later in their lives, how long these returners have spent on the escalator before quitting it and how different are the social mobility achievements of the staying and departing groups. The answers are important due to their implications for regional growth and policy making in both the escalator region and the remainder of the country, as discussed in the concluding section.

The escalator region model

Origins

The hypothesis of the escalator region was first articulated formally by Fielding in his 1992 paper ‘Migration and social mobility: south-east England as an escalator region’. It appears to have had two main antecedents. One was the growing recognition during the 1980s of the effect of place on life chances. People possessing the same qualifications and achieving the same levels of work performance were nevertheless observed to experience quite different occupational class trajectories in different places (Ashton et al., 1987; Peck and Haughton, 1987). The other was the identification of a ‘missing link’ in contemporary research, which was seen as having neglected the relationship between social and geographical mobility (Savage, 1988). Given that this neglect could be attributed partly to the lack of suitable data, a big opportunity for rectifying this came with the linking of people’s 1971 and 1981 census records in the LS. At the end of his 1989 study of inter-regional migration and social

change using this data source, Fielding felt able to generalize “about the role of south-east England in the recent history of the British economy and society”, most importantly that this region “attracted to itself many of England and Wales’ highly qualified young people” and, more generally, acted as “a kind of escalator for those who wanted to ‘get on’ in life” (Fielding, 1989, 35).

As developed by Fielding (1992, 3), the concept of the escalator region thus “incorporates the idea that by migrating from one region to another, individuals ‘step off’ one escalator and ‘step onto’ another”. For the young and ambitious, the key to social promotion is seen as combining an energetic pursuit of career advancement with ‘a judicious use of spatial differences’. Some regions act as faster escalators than others or indeed some are seen as upward escalators and others as downward ones. Also, within the context of time-lagged regional economic cycles, the running speed of the various escalators might vary relative to each other, though this is not something that Fielding explicitly allowed for. He was primarily concerned with the longer term and with testing for the existence of the escalator region concept by reference to the most likely candidate within England and Wales, namely the London region which he defined generously in the form of the then South East Standard Region.

Fielding (1992, 3–4) set out the following three “conditions that would need to be met before a region could be correctly categorized as an (upward) escalator region”:

1. That the region would attract to itself many young people at the start of their working lives: in particular, it would attract young people with promotion potential, such as those with qualifications, those seeking to gain such qualifications and those who are most prepared to relocate themselves for the sake of personal advancement. This is stage one—stepping on the escalator.
2. That the region would provide the context within which these in-migrants, together with many of those born and brought up in the region, would achieve accelerated upward social mobility through movement within the region’s labour

and housing markets. This is stage two—being taken up by the escalator.

3. That the region would then lose through out-migration a significant proportion of those who had experienced this upward social mobility. These out-migrants would be in the middle or later stages of their working lives or at or near retirement. They would migrate partly to ‘cash in’ the assets gained during their social promotion in the escalator region. ... The product of the realization of these assets would be the establishment for the individual of a position of high social status and/or considerable economic security and influence in an environmentally attractive non-escalator region. This is stage three—stepping off the escalator.

In doing this, Fielding (1992, 4) stressed four advantages of the escalator metaphor in handling the connections between geographical and social mobility. It emphasizes the youthful, low-status character of the in-migrant flows relative to the middle-aged, high-status character of the out-migration flows. It stresses the importance of factors other than the personal attributes of the individual—in this case regional location—which contribute to that individual’s life chances. It expresses the social and political significance of the economic geography of the country. Finally, it asserts the crucial role of migration in social promotion. Even so, says Fielding (1992, 4), “These advantages amount to nothing, unless it can be shown that certain regions (such as south-east England) do indeed display the expected properties of an escalator region”. This testing is what Fielding undertook in the remainder of his 1992 paper and in several subsequent studies while also stimulating other researchers to conduct their own related investigations.

Initial testing

Before going into more detail about the third stage of the model that is the main focus of the present study, it is useful to see how Fielding (1992) tested all three of the necessary conditions and what conclusions he drew from this (see also Fielding,

1993). Starting with the crucial second stage, the LS data were used to compare the south-east with the other Standard Regions and Wales with respect to the rate of promotion for their non-migrants. These analyses confirmed that those who did not change region between 1971 and 1981 faced very different rates of upward social mobility depending on where they lived. There was a clear 'geography of opportunity', greatly favouring those living in the south-east, where the rates of transition into managerial and professional work from both education and working-class jobs were much higher than in other regions. The south-east was thus seen to provide the best regional context for people from other parts of the country wanting to move up in the world.

In relation to the three conditions of the escalator process described above, the 'stepping-on' stage was tested with data on migration by age drawn from National Health Service records. This confirmed the substantial net gain of young adults made by the south-east through its exchanges with the rest of the country. Next, in terms of 'being taken up by the escalator', LS-based analysis of the change in economic position and broad occupation experienced by the people who had moved into the south-east between 1971 and 1981 revealed the beneficial effects of doing this. Over the decade, there had been a net shift from having been in education or unemployment in 1971 before their move to having professional, managerial or other white-collar jobs by 1981. Third, as regards the stepping-off stage, the NHS migration data showed the south-east to be a net supplier of 60- to 69-year olds to all but one of the other counties making up England and Wales and of 40- to 49-year olds to a majority of them. Moreover, LS-based analysis of people who left the south-east between 1971 and 1981 showed how their profile had switched away from professional, managerial and other white-collar work towards being retired and self-employed, the latter including the owners of small and medium-sized businesses (who Fielding refers to as 'petite bourgeoisie') and the overall effect being one of downshifting.

On the basis of such evidence, Fielding (1992) felt able to conclude that south-east England does indeed act as an escalator region in his terms. It

provides greater opportunities for upward social mobility than other regions and it performs a pivotal role in a circular migration process attuned to the life course, making net gains of younger and less experienced people at the expense of the rest of the country and losing the older and more experienced. At the same time, however, he sounds some cautionary notes. In particular, these initial tests also showed that migration into the south-east led to social demotion for some, though he accounts for this in terms of migrants moving from positions of weakness such as being made redundant in their home region during the inter-censal decade. Second, he stressed that migration associated with the escalator region model is only one of three major processes leading to what we would now refer to as human capital growth in the region, the others being international immigration and the region's indigenous generation of skilled labour.

Subsequent studies

Since 1992 a number of studies have updated, extended and further tested the basic model. Much of this work has been carried out by Fielding himself, with a particular focus on updating to the 1981–1991 inter-censal transition period and comparing the experiences of males and females. Other UK researchers, besides also examining male/female differences, have aimed at separating out the effect of the move itself from that of events after the move and have considered the role of migrant selectivity. This section briefly summarizes the principal findings of the part of this work that relates to the first two elements of the model before going into rather more detail on the final, stepping-off or return, stage.

Perhaps, the most important finding, given that Fielding's original test was based on the 1971–1981 inter-censal period, is that the role of south-east England as an escalator region was not confined to that decade. Fielding himself showed to be very conscious of the time-specific nature of some spatial economic patterns, for instance attributing the surge of 'counterurbanization' in the early 1970s to the 'last fling of Fordism' (Fielding, 1998, 45). He

rooted the emergence of the escalator region process in the changing organization of economic activity, namely the shift from regional sector specialization to the 'new spatial division of labour', but was already identifying a further shift towards what he called 'regional functional disconnection'. As part of the accelerating process of globalization, this development was seen to have particular resonance for a 'global city' like London, which was seeing ever-increasing reliance on international labour recruitment at the expense of the labour supply from the rest of the UK. Yet, reviewing his own work on 1981–1991 (notably Fielding and Halford, 1999) as well as the more recent research of others, Fielding (2007) concluded that south-east England has continued to satisfy the three key conditions of the escalator region.

The studies that have compared the experience of men and women conclude that migration to the London region from other regions, on balance, increases the likelihood of upward mobility for both, but especially so for women. The original reporting of this result by Fielding and Halford (1993) raised eyebrows at the time because conventional wisdom had it that longer distance moves were normally dictated by the employment considerations of male partners. It was widely accepted that the 'trailing spouse' or 'tied migrant' played second fiddle and often had to accept work that was inferior to the pre-move job as a result of what has been termed a 'constrained migration'. Nevertheless, Bruegel's (1999, 2000) analyses of in-migration to London confirmed the faster upward social mobility of women than men and helped to explain the apparent contrast with expectations. It turned out that, much more than for inter-regional migration in general, the female flow to London is composed of young, unattached women without child-care responsibilities. Other suggested reasons include London's labour market being more open to female advancement than provincial ones and its larger size and more extensive public transport network reducing the downsides of any 'tied migration'.

The challenge of separating out the effect of the move itself as opposed to events after the move has been addressed by the analysis by Findlay et al.

(2009) of Scotland-born people living in south-east England. Of the 226 such people identified by their survey, the vast majority of these (82%) had moved in order to take up their first job, of whom just under one-third had moved into a higher status job subsequently. Of the remaining 18% who had been in work before they left Scotland for south-east England, just over half achieved upward social mobility at the time of their move and around a third of these had gained further promotion. Rather confusingly, people who gained as a direct result of the move itself are termed 'escalators', while 'elevators' is the label given to those who gained promotion during their subsequent career in the south-east. A third type, 'travelators', are migrants who remained at the same occupational level as before their move from Scotland.

Turning to the studies that have dealt more with the final element of the model, their main emphasis has been on the process of people leaving the escalator region and 'cashing in' on the assets that they managed to accumulate during their time there. Such studies have focused most notably on the impacts on the 'non-metropolitan south' of England. For instance, Fielding (1998) showed that the south-west saw a rapid expansion of its middle-class population as a result of its migration exchanges. At the same time, this work also confirmed downshifting as the dominant pattern of behaviour among those moving there from the south-east, this being especially so for women with their higher probability of switching into less skilled work or out of the labour force entirely. This association of the stepping-off process with downward social mobility is entirely consistent with the body of literature that explains counterurbanization in terms of people 'voting with their feet' for a better quality of life (for example Champion, 1989, 2005; Findlay and Rogerson, 1993). Some of its least positive impacts on local economic development have been documented for Cornwall, where Williams and Champion (1998) used LS data to demonstrate the substantial falls in both labour force participation and occupational status among those moving there from south-east England and found local evidence on the way in which many such migrants used their assets to set up tourist-

related enterprises that yielded financial returns much lower than their previous salaries.

Other studies, however, have revealed a generally much wider range of people among the migrants leaving the escalator region, including some still at a relatively early stage of their working lives. For instance, following much earlier work by Gordon (1982), Findlay et al. (2008) looked at the stepping-off process from the perspective of Scotland-born people moving back to Scotland after a period of residence in south-east England. Using census data from both the LS and the samples of anonymized records, they concluded that, while young professional and managerial people recognize the benefit of adding to their CVs and skills portfolios through time spent in the London region early in their careers, they seem ready to leave again as soon as a suitable opportunity arises, with the university-educated being among the first to return northwards. Similarly, in their study of the occupational trajectories and migration practices of 59 young professional men and women working in producer services in Manchester, Devine et al. (2003) found that many of their sample—whether they originated from north-west England or elsewhere—had already spent time working in London. Given that the vast majority of their interviewees were aged under 35 years, these people must have spent a relatively short time on the London escalator. Of course, this is not to say that they might not have found others who had stayed in London longer if their sample had included more older workers, but it certainly raises a question about how far the stepping-off process is in actual fact dominated by people reaching the end of their careers—the answer to which has potentially important implications for the economic fortunes of the destination area as well as those of the escalator region itself.

Aim and approach

The aim of the present study is to probe what seems from the above review to be an area of inconsistency between what some of the more recent studies have discovered about the nature of the process of stepping off the regional escalator and the expectations

of the original hypothesis. In particular, while the latter emphasizes this as an event occurring towards the end of people's working lives after moving to south-east England early in their careers, it would now appear that at least some of those who migrate to take advantage of the escalator stay on it only a relatively short time and are still quite young when they depart, suggesting that a considerable portion of their remaining working lives will likely be spent where they move to. With the benefit of hindsight, the model's expectations in this respect do run counter to migration theory, most notably that the widely evidenced ideas that people's propensity to migrate tends to peak in the early adult years and that someone who has migrated previously has a higher chance of a future move than a non-migrant (see, for instance Boyle et al., 1998). Also, it now appears strange that, while disaggregating some of his analyses of social mobility by gender, Fielding never examined the age dimension of this, choosing to rely on data on net migration by age to test this aspect of the stepping-off process rather than looking at the age profile of just those leaving south-east England. Another opportunity missed by Fielding was that, when doing his later work on 1981–1991, he did not link these analyses back to the experiences of the same people in the previous decade and so was not in a position to check how many of those who had moved into south-east England in 1971–1981 were still living and working there in 1991.

This study addresses these two omissions while providing a more comprehensive and robust understanding of the nature of the stepping-off process than is available so far. In the first place, therefore, it examines the age profile of those moving out of south-east England rather than the age composition of the net migration balance between the moves into and the moves out of the region. For this purpose, data are taken from the 1991 census on inter-regional migration over the previous 12 months. Second, it follows those who moved into the south-east through a longer period of their subsequent lives than previous studies. For this, like Fielding, we rely on the LS, but here advantage is taken of the fact that this dataset now spans four censuses,

1971–2001, and links up the records of a 4-in-365 (that is just over 1%) sample of (surviving) individuals across these censuses. The present study also benefits from the 1971 census's inclusion of a question on people's address 5 years before, so the analysis focuses on those who moved to the south-east from the rest of England and Wales between 1966 and 1971, with the data from the next three censuses being used to identify any change in their whereabouts and personal characteristics over the following 30 years.

The LS-based analysis aims to answer three questions with reference to this cohort of LS members (LSMs) who stepped onto the regional escalator between 1966 and 1971:

1. What proportion of the people entering the escalator region early in their lives left it again later in their lives, that is 'stepped off the escalator' (and did this by 2001)?
2. With respect to those who had left the escalator region by 2001, how much later in their lives did this move take place, that is how were these departures phased over time between 1971 and 2001?
3. Is there any difference in social mobility between those who had stepped off the escalator by 2001 and those who remained on it then?

This final question aims to obtain a better insight into the regional implications of this process. These impacts will vary according to whether the 'returners' turn out to be on average the more successful of those riding the escalator or the less successful. They will also vary in terms of the length of time elapsing before their return, which will affect the age at which they return and therefore for how long after their return they are likely to remain active in the labour market. These two may also interact with each other, though not perhaps in any readily predictable way according to the conventional wisdom on return migration. As set out by Boyle et al. (1998), it may be those who find it difficult to progress in their new environment that predominate among the early returners, or alternatively, these people may remain longer in the escalator region

in order to try and achieve their original goals and it is those who rise rapidly that may leave earlier because of more quickly meeting their goals or because of 'burn-out'.

Turning to the specifics of the analyses, the key decisions concern the geographical frame of reference, the metric of social mobility and the selection of the population. As far as is practicable, this study follows Fielding's methodology so that any differences in results cannot be put down merely to adopting a different approach. With regard to geography, therefore, the escalator region is defined as the former south-east Standard Region comprising Greater London and 12 surrounding counties and, as with Fielding, the focus is on migration between this and the aggregate of the rest of England and Wales. The study also follows Fielding's original approach in its classification of 'social groups', though adding some disaggregation. As shown in Table 1, this separates out four categories of people who are not in work, as did Fielding, while those who were working in the week before the census are classified seven ways on the basis of socioeconomic group (SEG) as opposed to Fielding's four-fold grouping. Because SEG had been replaced by National Statistics—Socioeconomic Classification by the time of the 2001 census, the relevant information from that census has been used to generate the SEG of each LSM at this time. The only departure from Fielding's set-up is in terms of the population analysed. Whereas his analyses were not restricted by age, the aim of this study predetermines that the focus should be on LSMs who moved to the escalator region from elsewhere in England and Wales in the earlier stages of their lives and also had a good chance of surviving to the end of the reference period. The sample therefore comprises those who were under 35 years old in 1966 and could be coded to somewhere in England and Wales in all four censuses, 1971–2001.

Results

The presentation of results begins with examining the age profile of those moving out of south-east England so as to see the extent to which the process

Table 1. Comparison of Fielding's 'social class' classification with that used in present study.

Fielding's (1992)	SEG of employed	This study	SEG of employed
Service class	1, 2.2, 3, 4, 5.1	Managerial	1, 2.2
		Professional	3, 4, 5.1
Petite bourgeoisie	2.1, 12, 13, 14	Petite bourgeoisie	2.1, 12, 13, 14
White collar	5.2, 6, 7	White collar	5.2, 6
		Personal service	7
Blue collar	8, 9, 10, 11, 15, 17	Skilled manual	8, 9
		Other employed	10, 11, 15, 16, 17
Unemployed		Unemployed	
In education		In education	
Retired		Retired	
Other		Other inactive	
Population: all living in England and Wales in both 1971 and 1981		Population: all living in England and Wales aged under 36 in 1966 and also there in 1971, 1981 and 2001	

of leaving the escalator region is skewed towards people reaching the end of their working lives. After this, the section concentrates on the post-1971 experiences of those who stepped onto the south-east escalator between 1966 and 1971, tackling in turn the three questions about this group set out in the previous section but again focusing particularly on the extent to which these people remained on the escalator till approaching the end of their working lives.

The age profile of people leaving the escalator region

As mentioned above, the extent to which people at or nearing retirement age will have been involved in the stepping-off-the-escalator flows analysed by Fielding is examined here by reference to data taken from the 1991 census on inter-regional migration over the previous 12 months. This census was chosen in preference to the latest available one, because it uses the same Standard Statistical Region framework as Fielding rather than the successor Government Office Region (GOR) system (which places three counties north of London in a new East of England GOR with East Anglia) and also uses vacation address for students rather than the term-time address adopted in 2001. In any case, however, the choice of year matters little because, unlike for the net migration balance, the patterning of gross inter-regional migration tends to alter only slowly over time.

These data show very clearly that older people make up only a relatively small proportion of people leaving south-east England. Out of the more than 190,000 people living elsewhere in England and Wales at the 1991 census who indicated that their address one year previously had been in the south-east, those aged 45 and over made up only around 36,000, or less than one in five, and barely half of these were 60 or more. Just over one in five were aged 30–44 years and one in six were children under the age of 16. By far the largest number—some 82,000 or more than two-fifths—of these out-migrants comprised 16- to 29-year olds, despite this group excluding by definition people moving to and from university, as just mentioned.

This picture should come as no surprise given the consistency of gross migration rate schedules which indicate young adulthood as the peak time in the life course for moving home, with rates falling off steadily after the late twenties and only a much smaller and shorter rise around retirement age (see, for instance Stillwell et al., 1992). At the same time, it is not wholly contrary to the description of the final stage of the escalator region model quoted above, as this outflow from the south-east will include older people who have benefited from living in the escalator region. On the other hand, it can now be seen that the overall social mobility changes observed by Fielding for people stepping off the escalator will have been driven as much by

migrants of younger working age as by those in the middle or later stages of their working lives. What this form of analysis—also being for a single migration period—cannot show, however, is the extent to which those leaving the south-east are people who previously moved there to take advantage of its escalator effects, nor whether any such were predominantly of older working age as opposed to being younger people who had spent a relatively short part of their working life span on the escalator. These aspects can be studied only by reference to a dataset which tracks the whereabouts of people over more than two time points, which is what the linked census records in the LS—along with the 5-year-ago address in the 1971 census—make possible.

What proportion of the people moving to the escalator region early in their lives leaves it again?

The first of the three research questions to be tackled with the LS-derived data concerns the extent to which those who step on to the regional escalator subsequently step off it or at least had done so by the end of the reference period, 2001. This can be answered by identifying the LSMs who moved to south-east England between 1966 and 1971 (and were still there in 1971) and seeing how many were still living there in 2001. In all, the 1971 census records in the LS show that, among those who also had census records for 1981 and 2001, there were 3136 LSMs aged 35 or less in 1966 who were living in the south-east in 1971 but had had an address somewhere else in England and Wales 5 years earlier. This is equivalent to 286,000 people based on the sampling fraction, but for present purposes, it is sufficient to continue to refer only to the LSM counts and derived ratios.

Turning to the whereabouts of these 3136 LSMs in 2001, it is found that 1721 of them were still resident in the south-east then, that is between 30 and 35 years after their migration into the escalator region. But as a corollary, 1415 had left the south-east for somewhere else in England and Wales over this 30-year period. The latter represents 45.1% of the original cohort who were identified as stepping onto the escalator between 1966 and 1971.

While these returners are not in the majority, this 45% share can be considered large enough to constitute the ‘significant proportion’ that Fielding (1992, see above) specified as part of his test of the third element of his regional escalator model. This is especially so if it is borne in mind that not all the LSMs in this migrant cohort will have reached or even neared the end of their working lives by 2001, with the cohort’s ages now ranging from 36 to 70. For many, there is potentially still plenty of time after 2001 to step off the escalator. If the model is correct, the proportion would be likely to rise further as more of this cohort approaches pensionable age.

One way of checking on the likelihood of the proportion of returners increasing after 2001 is to divide the cohort into two age groups (at age 55/56) and compare their up-till-2001 return rates. The older group, aged 56–70 years in 2001 and thus made up of people who by then had passed pensionable age or were getting close to it, accounts for 1203 of the 3136 migrants. Of these, 512 or 42.6% were again resident outside the south-east by 2001. Meanwhile, of the 1933 migrants aged 36–55 years in 2001, 903 or 46.7% were no longer living there in 2001. Clearly, somewhat more of the younger part of the in-migrant cohort of 1966–1971 than of the older one had left the south-east by 2001—something that would not be expected if most of those stepping on the escalator were spending most of their working lives there before stepping off it again. There are a number of possible explanations for this finding that we will return to after addressing the two remaining questions.

How much time did these returners spend in the escalator region?

Having just seen that 1415 of the 3136 LSMs who moved into the south-east in 1966–1971 were living back outside the escalator region in 2001, how much later in their lives did this move take place? In other words, how were these return moves phased over time between 1971 and 2001 or, more specifically, in which of the three inter-censal decades did they leave the south-east? In particular, were the moves concentrated in the final decade

1991–2001, that is later in their working lives, or more evenly spread?

The answer to this question, as shown in Table 2, is that the process of stepping off the escalator was by no means evenly spread but contrary to original expectation was concentrated in the first of the three decades following their move to the south-east. A total of 1089 of the 3136 LSMs stepping onto the escalator in 1966–1971 were reported in the 1981 census as being back outside the south-east, that is 35%. This figure represents fully 7 out of every 10 of the 1415 LSMs who had stepped off the escalator by 2001. Many fewer of this in-migrant cohort left the south-east in the two subsequent decades: 287 in 1981–1991 and just 195 in 1991–2001.

In fact, as also shown by Table 2, the answer is a bit more complicated than this because between 1981 and 2001, there were also a number of moves back to the south-east by some of these returners. The census records show that 104 of the 1098 LSMs who had stepped onto the escalator in 1966–1971 and stepped off it by 1981 were back in the south-east by 1991. Then, out of the net 1281 who were back in the rest of the country by 1991, 61 were again living in the south-east in 2001. Assuming that most of these people recorded their whereabouts accurately at each of the censuses, this finding suggests a degree of fluidity in the behaviour of at least an element of those of this cohort.

Therefore, while a fair proportion of those migrating into the escalator region leave it again, it is not only that the latter process is not restricted to people reaching the end of their working lives but

also that the probability of leaving the south-east (and doing this by 2001) is highest in the first decade after the initial move and tails off substantially thereafter. With the available data, it is difficult to be precise about how much time these LSMs spent ‘riding the escalator’. For 7 out of 10 of them, however, it can have been no longer than the 15 years elapsing between 1966 and 1981, the earliest and the latest dates of moving to and from the south-east, and for many of these the length of stay may have been much shorter. At the other extreme, however, are the 55% of the original in-migrants who remained in the south-east in 2001. For many of these, given their 36–70 age span in 2001, there is still the opportunity of leaving at or before retirement.

Is there any difference in social mobility between those who had stepped off the escalator by 2001 and those who remained on it then?

This final question addresses the possibility that the escalator process may be bimodal in its socio-economic outcomes, which may be related to the timing of the stepping-off process. Having discovered that the majority of those who had stepped off the escalator by 2001 had spent only a relatively short period of their working lives there, the aim now is to see whether these people had been finding it more difficult to progress their careers in the escalator region than those who stayed on for longer. Moreover, from the escalator model’s emphasis on later working age for this stage of the process, it could be expected that the degree of benefit gained

Table 2. *The regional location, 1966–2001, of those who moved to the south-east (SE) from the rest of England and Wales (REW) between 1966 and 1971.*

Period	In REW at start of period	From REW to SE	From SE to REW	In REW at end of period	In SE at end of period	
					No.	%
1966–1971	3136	3136	n/a	0	3136	100.0
1971–1981	0	n/a	1098	1098	2038	65.0
1981–1991	1098	104	287	1281	1855	59.2
1991–2001	1281	61	195	1415	1721	54.9

Note: n/a, not applicable.

by riding the escalator would be proportional to the length of time spent on it. The analysis in this section therefore uses the 'social class' classification (see above, Table 1) to compare those who had left by 2001 (returners, most of whom had left within 15 years of their arrival) with those who were living in the south-east at least 30 years after their move there (for convenience here termed 'non-returners', even though a few of them are known to have spent some time outside the south-east over this period).

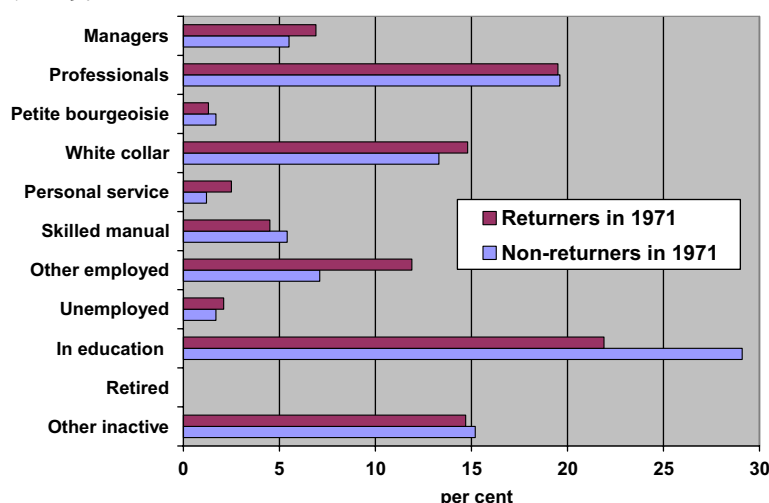
Two key comparisons are made in Figure 1. Panel A shows their profiles in 1971, which is the first date at which people in the LS can be classified on the basis of their labour market position and occupational status and represents their situation within 5 years of moving to the south-east from elsewhere in England and Wales. At this time there would generally seem to be only minor differences between the returners and the non-returners. In both cases, around one-fifth were working in professional occupations, a bit over 5% as managers, just under 15% in the main part of what Fielding terms 'white-collar proletariat' and about 5% in skilled manual jobs, with fewest of both being in the petite bourgeoisie and personal service categories. Both groups also contained similar proportions of unemployed persons and 'other inactive' (people neither in the labour market nor in education). There are, however, two respects in which the two are more differentiated: the greater representation of the 'other employed' (primarily semi-skilled and unskilled workers) for the subsequent returners and the higher share of those still in full-time education for the non-returners. These two differences are suggestive of a somewhat lower level of achievement by 1971 among those who had stepped off the escalator by 2001 and, in most cases, by 1981.

An alternative explanation for whether or not people had stepped off the escalator by 2001 is that there were differences in their post-1971 career trajectories. To test this, Figure 1B examines the profiles of the returners and non-returners at the end of the reference period in 2001. Both of them have shifted in similar ways from their situation 30 years before. Reflecting the fact that these LSMs are now aged 36–70 years, more than one-fifth consider

themselves to be in retirement. Among those in work, in 2001 compared to 1971, there were more in the three highest status categories of professional, managerial and petite bourgeoisie, indicating the general upgrading that would be expected of people who had aged by 30 years, whereas the shares of the four intermediate and lower status categories had either stayed broadly the same or fallen. Turning to the comparison of the profiles of returners and non-returners in 2001, there is even less difference between the two than there had been in 1971. Their proportions of retired people are identical, while at the other extreme less than 2 percentage points are involved in the two biggest differences, whereby the returning group contains somewhat fewer in professional work and somewhat more in the petite bourgeoisie category.

On this evidence, there seems to be remarkably little difference in social status and mobility between the returners and the non-returners. First, while there are no data on their pre-move characteristics that could be used to check whether the two groups derive from different stock, the strong similarity of their profiles in 1971 suggests that the decision to step off the escalator subsequently had little to do with the ease or otherwise of inserting themselves into the south-east's labour market in the first few years after their arrival. Second, the even greater similarity in their profiles in 2001 similarly suggests that the decision on whether to stay on or step off the escalator by then was influenced hardly at all by how their careers progressed over this period. It would seem that the returners were dominated neither by those who had found it hardest to take advantage of the south-east's escalator properties nor by those who had been most successful in quickly reaping the rewards of being there. These assertions, however, need to be qualified by the fact that for the majority of the returners—those who had left the south-east by 1981—there is no post-1971 information on their attainment level immediately before their departure, only on what they were doing in 1981 when already somewhere else in the country. Finally, what these results also signify is that the returners would appear to have prospered just as much as the non-returners, despite the fact that the

A: In 1971



B: In 2001

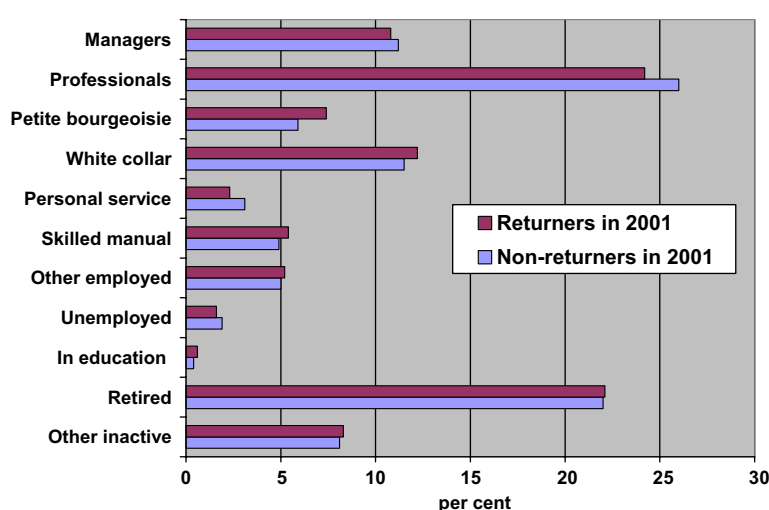


Figure 1. 'Social class' of returners and non-returners.

majority of them had left the escalator region by 1981 and been exposed to the weaker labour market conditions elsewhere for at least 20 years.

Discussion

Since its formulation two decades ago, the escalator region model has stimulated much research bearing on the relationship between migration and regional growth. With the rise of the knowledge economy

and the importance of high-quality human capital in this, research has confirmed the attractive pull of the largest cities and the more rapid social mobility achieved there, while other places' stakeholders have bemoaned the exodus of their young talent and looked for ways of stemming it. Less consistent with the model, however, have been the findings relating to the final stepping-off element of Fielding's model, notably surveys showing people

returning after a relatively short time on the escalator rather than later in their careers. The timing of this move will affect the impact that people leaving the escalator region will have on the labour supply side of the rest of the country, as also will the type and level of their previous work experience.

Using the relatively large sample size of the LS to obtain a more comprehensive picture of the stepping-off process than that provided by these survey-based studies, the analysis of those who moved to south-east England between 1966 and 1971 has broadly confirmed the latter's findings. While it endorses the model's hypothesis that a significant proportion of those engaging in the escalator process do step off it again, it is clear that the majority had done so after spending less than 15 years on it, with much smaller numbers of them moving back subsequently (by 2001). Moreover, no doubt partly because of the relatively young age of most of these returners (their age span in 1981 was 16–50, with almost two-thirds being 35 or less) as well as because of the skills and experience which they will have acquired during their stay in the south-east, they appear to have subsequently been contributing just as much to their regional economies as their non-returning counterparts have in the south-east, this being in terms of both their proportion in work and their occupational distribution (as seen in Figure 1B). On the basis of this evidence, therefore, it would seem that the downside for the regions of origin has not been as great as implied by the escalator region model, with its emphasis on people returning much later in their lives when they are tending to 'downshift' or are already retired and then contributing to the economy there mainly through their spending power.

At the same time, it has to be admitted that the results presented above do little more than scratch the surface of this aspect of the relationship between migration and regional change. There are several ways in which the present study could be refined and developed. One would be to further restrict the sample of people analysed, by focusing on those who had reached working age or even entered the labour market by the time that they moved to south-east England. While students' moves to and from university have automatically been excluded

by their being coded to term-time address in censuses before 2001, in retrospect, there is a case for excluding those who were still in education in 1971 after their move to the south-east, given that most of these are likely to have moved there with their parents.

In terms of the analysis, perhaps the most obvious next step is to separate out the three phases of returners (1971–1981, 1981–1991 and 1991–2001) and compare their progress both before and after leaving the south-east, perhaps disaggregated by gender as well as with a more detailed breakdown of age. Another line of investigation would involve a regional breakdown of the rest of England and Wales in order to probe whether some parts of the country outside the south-east were affected more by the stepping-off-the-escalator process than others, including seeing how far the returners actually went back to their region of origin or moved to a different region (technically becoming 'onward migrants') and whether their choice of particular region affected their prospects. Micro-level regressions would be of benefit here, not just because of the likelihood of cross-tabulations running into disclosure problems because of small sample size but also to help isolate the impacts of personal characteristics such as gender, family status and industry of employment and identify any selection effects. Additionally, sample size could be increased by including other population groups in the modelling, such as comparing the returners with those leaving the south-east for the first time or comparing those who moved to the south-east with those who remained in their home region.

There are also research opportunities in terms of updating the analysis. While this paper has been able to track people's spatial and social mobility over three inter-censal decades, the attaching of 2011 census data to LSMs' records will permit this monitoring to extend over an additional 10 years when more of the 1966–1971 cohort who were still riding the escalator in 2001 will have reached retirement age and might have decided to leave the south-east then. The extra time afforded by the 2011 census also increases the value of studying later cohorts of people stepping onto the escalator. Most notably, for those who moved into south-east England between 1971 and 1981, their life courses can now be

followed for a further 30 years. Moreover, given that the results in this paper have stressed the relatively short time spent on the escalator by many of these migrants, there is also value in examining how many of those who moved to the south-east in 1981–1991 were still living there in 2001 and 2011, and similarly how many of the 1991–2001 cohort were still there in 2011, though analysis of these last two cohorts will need to allow for the switch in 2001 from vacation to term-time address for students.

Finally, a more complete picture of escalator region migration dynamics may be possible from other sources besides the linked census records in the LS, with particular benefits to be gained from datasets that allow more frequent monitoring than once every 10 years. One such—the British Household Panel Study with its annual waves since 1991—has traditionally been of limited value for studying inter-regional migration because of its small sample size, but its incorporation into the larger Understanding Society survey offers the chance of more robust results for this work. Another alternative is the Annual Survey of Hours and Earnings, with its 1% sample of people in work and now providing details of both residence and workplace, though only a very limited set of personal characteristics. Also, given the 2010 decision to abandon the decennial population census, there is hope of a large and more frequently updated dataset based on linking together data on individual people derived from administrative sources.

In conclusion, this paper has reported the results of a study which, though clearly exploratory in nature given the long list of follow-up work just outlined, has provided sufficient evidence to call into question one of the key features of the escalator region model. Moreover, in a context of national economic slowdown and increasing regional inequalities, the findings are also of considerable policy relevance. While attracting human capital in the first place seems to be the privilege of relatively few regions, retaining it is a major challenge for many more regions. Beyond this, the idea of regions developing strategies to reclaim skilled labour resources that have previously leached away from them can reap much bigger dividends than the original formulation of the model suggested.

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